

[CONFIDENTIAL]

INVESTIGATION REPORT : 03/04/2023, Sector E. Outbreak

CASE_A

[Zarif Rezwan; Faculty Member (Professor), Genetics Department, Dhaka University [DECEASED]. Major laceration along left side of torso, wounds on hands and face strongly implies subject engaged in conflict(s) shortly preceding death. Time of Death; 0230, Cause; Headshot by Special Forces Responders. Discovered in Sector E Storage Unit 06 post-transformation.]

[The following are the contents of the several pages found within the notepad of Zarif Rezwan [DECEASED] in the Security Room of Ammunition Storage Unit 06, on 01/04/2023 at 0240 hrs. The contents of the pages have been kept largely unaltered with the sole exception being the comments by our investigator]

As long as I'm stuck here, I've got literally nothing to do. It got real boring real quick and so here I am scribbling away on this notepad. Funny thing is, I thought writing something would alleviate my boredom, yet when I took out my pen and tried to unleash the inner writer within me, I realised that my mind had gotten completely blank. Just like that, Poof! All the things I was thinking about writing simply vanished. But I guess that was to be expected, I mean, who can possibly just spontaneously start writing about... stuff? This was probably a stupid idea anyway because I'm still hella bored.

Well, I guess I should start with how I got here, that seems like a good topic to begin on. It was around 1am, I think, we were on a routine patrol. My assigned partner for this shift was a third year student whose name escapes me at the moment. I'm sure he's a nice kid, but I personally had never met him before. The patrol was thus far a very normal one, nothing out of the ordinary. No sightings, no suspicious noises, no undead. Pretty monotonous. It was so uneventful, in fact, that we spent most of our time criticising the government's recent decision to cease all contact with our counterparts in Islamabad. I mean we're literally living in hell right now, and now is not the time to cut off relations with what few humans are still alive! And that too for geopolitical reasons of all things! You have beef with their

leaders? Sure, knock yourselves out. But most of the people there were scientists, working for a cure like the rest of us! This whole situation is just idiotic, those up above act like it is just another crisis they can fix politically. Morons, the lot of them!

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Anyway, I digress.

So, we were passing by the eastern wall near Shahbag, behind the ammunition building when we heard that blood-curdling sound. The moan was distinct and the both of us immediately knew what it was. The sound seemed to be coming from the building. We were a few kilometres from the Habitation Areas, but terrified at the idea of another outbreak within the safe zone, we ran in to investigate without waiting for backup. Time was of the essence.

My first thought was that there must be others, this can't possibly be an isolated incident. Runners don't appear out of thin air, they need a transmission vector. Tahmeed saw it first (Ah yes! That's what his name was- Tahmeed). I was quite far away from him at that time as we had decided to split up to search more effectively. But when I heard the poor guy scream, I realised shit had hit the fan. It took me approximately 3 minutes to reach Tahmeed, and in the meanwhile, the poor guy probably didn't have a choice but to engage the ghoul. And when I finally reached him, I felt a chill go down my spine. He was standing in a dimly-lit hallway next to the disembowelled corpse of a runner, his axe lodged into the thing's deformed Fungal head. He was facing away from me and so I couldn't quite see his face... Not that I needed to see his face, his bleeding left arm told me everything I needed to know.

I stood there, dumbfounded, not knowing whether I should do the deed before he turns or not. His body began spasming uncontrollably which signalled I didn't have much time left to decide. He let out an unholy scream which echoed throughout the building, and with that, I received my cue to discard all my empathetic concerns. I realised the pathogen had already reached his brain. He fell to the ground as the spasms grew evermore erratic. Then, about 30 seconds in, it all stopped. The spasms, the muffled cries, the screams- all subsided. The transformation was complete. He jumped up and began to make his way towards me. His eyes were now pitch black, bloated black veins were visible on his face. His hands twitched continuously but that didn't slow him down at all. "The Thing" gave off a screech as it made its final leap to take out its prey, Me. It lunged at me but I had my axe ready to greet it. I called out the name of the Almighty and put all my strength into the swing

and connected it right across the forehead. A single slash and it was all over. The hit sent its pre-frontal cortex flying out. Poor sod, but I really can't say that I'll miss him, we weren't that close after all. Still, we really can't afford to lose people like this- the nation's manpower is already thinned out as it is. We simply can't keep on losing people and that too in such ungodly ways.

[Investigator's note: Noticeable, but slight change in handwriting. Current hypothesis is that the subject took a break, before continuing]

So, here I am, stuck here until the men in uniform arrive. They usually don't take more than 20 minutes but god knows what's gotten into them today! I honestly thought they'd be here by now. Instead I've been waiting in this miniature hell for what feels like forever!

Since I had nothing better to do, I did a perimeter sweep and found 2 other runners but they weren't together so it wasn't really that hard to put them down. But this confirmed my fear; there has been an outbreak here. Couldn't find the transmission vector but by examining the corpses, I became certain that the infection had to be spread via spores. This meant that there has to be one of those advanced stage zombies somewhere in this very building. Great! So, like any rational person, I decided to hide. I am sitting in the control room of the weapons cache as I write this. I have no idea how something like that could've gone unnoticed for so long, but I ain't getting out until backup arrives.

Well since I've already explained how I've got here, let's talk about something else. I've been studying the Mortem fungi for years now. Long before the plague, back in 2019 when scientists had only just discovered the human strain of the 'zombie-ant' fungi. I was extremely fascinated by it. I entered this field of science mainly for that reason and studying it became my life. Shortly before the pandemic, it started mutating. It was uncovered that the fungi *Ophiocordyceps unilateralis* had formed a symbiotic relation with the H1N1 influenza virus, the symbiotic organism was later named Mortem, which I must say was the most idiotic thing anyone ever did. Good luck calming down the masses when you tell them there was an outbreak of a disease literally named "Death"!

So as I was saying, the pathogen attacks the central nervous system and hijacks the cerebellum. From there, it grows outgrowths to consolidate more control over the host, which remains its primary source of nutrition. The impacted cerebellum manifests in the patient exhibiting unsteady gait, and in some cases, spasms and partial seizures. And that's only the initial phase!

Next the amygdala and hypothalamus are assaulted. The infection in the amygdala means that the host is always hyper aggressive, like with rabies, and that in the hypothalamus means that the host is in a perpetual state of insatiable hunger. The contamination of the hypothalamus also over stimulates the adrenal gland which in turn leads to the excess production of adrenaline, giving the host superhuman strength. By this point, all higher brain functions of the patient are lost irreversibly. Any semblance of individuality or personality, hell, even traits like empathy or rationality, is completely purged from the body of the infected. Anyone who reaches this stage is no longer human, no longer even an animal. They are reduced to something far, far worse. They become, for the lack of a better word, a zombie.

And last but definitely not least, it reaches its ultimate form. Cytopathic reanimation. The dead cells literally come back to life. And as much as I hate to say this, we still haven't been able to crack that part yet. But what we do know, is that this leads to the infected developing lumbrical hypertrophy.

So, we now had a disease which was air borne, water borne and blood borne, which could turn those who were infected into hyper aggressive, blood thirsty, mindless monsters, that too with superhuman strength, and which could spread faster than the Spanish Flu.

I guess God decided a flood wouldn't suffice this time around, only the most sinister abomination from the deepest layer of hell would do. But to be honest, if you discard all the grimness associated with it, 'Mortem' was a truly fascinating specimen. When

That poor kid, Tahmeed. He probably didn't have a moment to truly register what was happening to him. Must have been tough. Text book symptoms of

[Investigator's Note: Subject seems to have left uneven gaps in his account for hitherto unexplained reasons. Several sentences in this section also appear to be incomplete or otherwise lacking coherence. Further graphological analysis is recommended]

It was mid 2020, I believe. When the war broke out. In the old Great War Fashion. Iran and Saudi Arabia went to war, and they called in their allies, then their allies called in their allies and then they called in theirs, so on and so forth. Turtles all the way down basically. Nuke usage was limited but the same couldn't be said for Biological weaponry unfortunately. Anthrax, the Bubonic Plague, Cholera- they were all good. all good. But 'Mortem' was simply better. In fact, it was the best.

The world's armies bombed the living shit out of each other with Mortem Shells. And thank God most cities built walls around them to combat that before the pandemic began. Otherwise, I have no doubt that Homo sapiens would now be an extinct species.

It began in Russia, August 2022. A massive US strike of Mortem Shells managed to penetrate the Russian Air Defence System. This strike was particularly successful, Slavic ground forces were utterly devastated. They failed to contain the outbreak and soon, everything outside of the walled citadels descended into complete anarchy. Russia and her allies retaliated by unleashing their entire arsenal on the West.

Europe was overrun by hordes midway through August, and by early September, most of the US East Coast had gone dark. Countries, now on the brink of annihilation, resorted to suing for peace, regardless of what the demands were. With the Human race struggling to survive, the War was finally grinding to a halt. But it wasn't over just yet. Late in September, I witnessed the same undoing of my homeland. With 70% of their population no longer human, China and Pakistan hit one last co-ordinated strike against their enemies; India and us. It was 7 months ago, on the 20th of September, and yet I remember it like yesterday.

It was around two in the morning of the 27th. I was working late that night. So I was still at the University when I heard the sirens go off. Air raid sirens. For a moment, I was hoping this time they would just shoot their nukes at us. That would've honestly been better. The University was within the safe zone, so I didn't have to worry too much. But the barrier wall was right beside us.

I had just reached the gate. I saw hundred if not thousands of people flocking to the Shahbagh gate, beside the Primary weapon cache(it used to be a museum once) the closest gate from where I was. They knew it just might be their last option to stay a human. Then; the night sky lit up. The anti-missile cannons were now firing full on. The mortem Shells were biohazards, so just shooting them would just make things worse. So, the cannons had to completely obliterate them. Understandably this took a lot of firepower. And thus, it suddenly felt like day was upon us. Deafening booms and fireballs covered the sky above. The cannons kept firing. Many times a second, even.

Then All the gates closed. Also the shahbagh one. Dhaka is a big city, or at least it was. Larger population than the entire country of Afghanistan. The government knew not closing now could mean trouble,. So they closed them. not caring what happens to the tens of millions outside the walls

The air defense system soon were getting overburdened. Shells began landing everywhere. The army took care of the stuff that happened inside the safe zone but outside? Noone knew what was happening outside. I geuss by the time I got inside, most of them had already transformed.

Successful strikes on Dhaka had happened several times over the past years years. But these time things were different. Nothing of this scale, of this magnitude ever took place. The final attack,so to speak, this was.

I had made it into one of those bunkers tey built near Curzon Hall not long after the attack began. And I remained their for the night. When me and the other peopel got out, risen the sun had. And the bombs had stopped. And from beyond the walls, I heard noises. Cries, moans and growls. None of them any longer human. I guess they achieved their goal finally after trying to bomb uss for drei years. They're were several outbreaks over the next few months,But they were all contained and the population inside remains uninfected. still

Goevrnment reports say they think the total numbers of surviors in the country are now somewhere around 30million, mostly in the primary urban safe zones.Outside those, a couple of thousands at best.

Onthe bright side hostilities between everyone seem to have died down.. too busy not become non existence. Its funny you know. Napidaw abruptly cut contact with everyone last week, [unclear] the zombies probably got them. And if that city has fallen, than that that means the myanmar has ceased to exist what a time to be alive

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I dont know why but I feel like it getting harder to write is, I simply kant seem to remember the words. I am [unclear] but I can t come with the words up. I'm still very conciousand

okay but I guess ive ran out of things to write abouut maybe the [unclear] boredom finally got to me [unclear] you understand !?

[Investigator's note: The Subject's writing style abruptly becomes very stressed and aggressive following this point, a higher frequency of 'unclear' sentences is also noticed]

I am having a very painful headache [unclear] I feel like my mind is being stuffed with cotton. I can't think straight. It hurts to think. I am starting to believe I got infected. Maybe one of those things scratched me or something I don't know. or maybe I inhaled some of those spores!? [unclear] But that's impossible! I didn't open my mask for a single moment [unclear]

or did I? I can't remember. god what have I done?! It must be the spores. has to be. I see no [unclear] injuries on my skin. But how is that possible, What in the world am I going to do now? And where are the [unclear] military?! They should have been here already. I am going to die here. Is this going to be all that's left? [unclear] I can let it go like this!

I need to write something for my friends and family.

[unclear, torn]

I can't go like this. I must [unclear] this,,, I must fight this until the army comes, [unclear] They'll know what to do. They'll help me. They'll get me fixed. I'll be all better. I will go back [unclear] and I will be okay. It all OK will be. Nothing is problem.

[Investigator's note: writing has become extremely erratic and the subject's handwriting has severely deteriorated. Several tears in the note is observed, presumably from the pressure applied by the subject]

I feel sad NO I feel angry. I don't know why. I feel like this was all tahmeed's fault,, [unclear] He got me into this [unclear, torn]

I feel so Angry. So so angry I want to kill him. [unclear, torn]

I need to find him. I will get up and will find him. I will kill him. [unclear, torn]

But wasn't he [unclear]? I can't remember. If he's dead I will kill him again. [unclear, torn]

I need to let go of this rage. I want to revenge. He is fault that I am dying. [unclear, torn]

I won't let this go unanswered. and facing army!!!! [unclear] Why are they so late?! I can hear them now. they are too late I am dead now. [unclear, torn]

I can't be helped I will kill them [unclear, torn]

when they come here. They has [unclear] made me very very angry

[Investigator's note: writing continues the trend of becoming increasingly obscure. At this point of the account, the handwriting has become nearly indiscernible. Further analysis has proved futile in decrypting a large part of the message]

[unclear] my leg wont move I lifted my pants and saw my feet not move [unclear] My entire body from below my chest has become completely unmoving [unclear, torn]

. I feel hungry. Very hungry the hungry is becoming more. [unclear] my left hand unmoving now. I feel hungry. Hungrier am struggling to write I must write I MUST [unclear, torn]

I am starving. I want to get up and look around [unclear] I need food. I need it,, left hand is moving on its own [unclear]

I can't help it. I can't stop it. It's moving more now. I feel [unclear] starving. And I can't move. But my left hand is moving I can't move. I am hungry. [unclear, torn]

my hand have black lines,,,

[Investigator's note: Most writing below this mark is completely incomprehensible. What little could be salvaged is as follows;

Subject repeatedly mentions an intolerable craving for sustenance, a severe distaste for the Special Forces (allegedly) responding late, and a desire to terminate his associate, who he claims is already deceased. Subject also fleetingly mentions darkened veins, spasms and headaches.

The remainder of the pages are filled with scribbles which could not be identified to hold any meaning]

[Prof. Zarif Rezwan is assumed to have undergone the final stages of transformation whilst writing this section, following which he engaged the Special Force Responders, during which he was fatally shot. Time of Death was taken at 0230]